

THE CONGRESS PRESIDENT WAS KEEN THAT A 'POLITICAL' MAN BE MADE FINANCE MINISTER



CHIDAMBARAM
AND SINGH (RIGHT)

DELHI | That Look In the Eye

After much speculation, it was decided the prime minister would keep the finance portfolio—at least for the Winter Session of Parliament. Under fire for allowing bureaucrats to get away with barely a reprimand post-26/11, the Congress chief was keen that a 'political' man be made finance minister. That scotched Manmohan's alternative shortlisted candidates M.S. Ahluwalia and C. Rangarajan. Sonia's candidate was former Karnataka chief minister S.M. Krishna, who was summoned to Delhi for a meeting with the Congress chief. It never took place. Manmohan though is happy to fill in the FM's role, one Union minister joking that the sight of a finance file gave Manmohan a look in his eye that other men got "when seeing a Playboy centrefold".

by Priya Sahgal

BANGALORE | Not So NICE

The much-hyped 111-km long Bangalore-Mysore expressway, promoted by Nandi Infrastructure Corridor Enterprise (NICE), has begun to er.. take its toll. NICE has begun to collect fees for the use of its roads. Former prime minister and JD(s) chief H.D. Deve Gowda calls the NICE move "very ugly". Road users must now make tough choices: in one case they can either use the eight-km NICE road at Rs 21 or spend an hour on the alternative free but slow 17-km route. "If time is money, the savings are obvious," says NICE promoter Ashok Kheny, promising a rethink on rates.

by Stephen David

THE BANGALORE-MYSORE EXPRESSWAY



MANJUNATH

KOLKATA |

Magic Realism

Hogwarts, beware. India's most famous magician P.C. Sorcar Jr is thinking of moving his proposed university of magic because the Government of India has not given it due priority. The university, which will award Masters of Illusions degrees, was planned for Sorcar's ancestral home in south Kolkata but may shift to the US or Australia. He said the venture needed 'crores', adding, "My lifetime is my deadline so I'm not fighting against time".

by Abhijit Dasgupta

THE CONGRESS HAS TARGETED THE INDUCTION OF SOME CORRUPTION-LINKED MINISTERS IN THE CHOUHAN CABINET.

CHOUHAN (EXTREME RIGHT) WITH HIS NEWLY APPOINTED MINISTERS



PANKAJ TIWARI

BHOPAL | House On Fire

Shivraj Singh Chouhan had barely finished celebrating his election triumph only to hear the rumblings of the disgruntled. The 22 new cabinet portfolios have annoyed a few senior ministers, like Kailash Vijayvargiya and Anup Mishra, nephew of former prime minister A.B. Vajpayee. Vijayvargiya, who earlier held PWD, was given commerce and industry while Mishra's water resources portfolio was replaced by the Health and Medical Education. The Congress is also pointing out that several in the Madhya Pradesh Cabinet have corruption cases that are still under investigation.

by Ambresh Mishra